ISLAMIC HISTORY AND CIVILIZATION

WORLD BEFORE ISLAM

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RELIGIOUS AND MORAL DECLINE

- BEFORE THE ADVENT OF ISLAM, THE WORLD WAS EXPERIENCING A DEEP SPIRITUAL AND MORAL CRISIS.
- THE ORIGINAL TEACHINGS OF EARLIER PROPHETS HAD BEEN LOST, FORGOTTEN, OR DELIBERATELY CHANGED OVER TIME.
- IDOL WORSHIP WAS PREVALENT ACROSS VARIOUS REGIONS, AND SOCIETIES WERE HEAVILY ENGAGED IN IMMORAL BEHAVIORS SUCH AS ALCOHOL CONSUMPTION, GAMBLING, USURY (INTEREST-BASED TRANSACTIONS), AND ADULTERY. ETHICAL GUIDANCE HAD DIMINISHED, AND HUMANITY NEEDED A DIVINE MESSAGE TO RESTORE JUSTICE, MORALITY, AND PURPOSE.

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THIS PERIOD IS OFTEN REFERRED TO IN THE QUR'AN AS "JAHILIYAH",

MEANING A TIME OF IGNORANCE

AND DEVIATION FROM DIVINE GUIDANCE

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JAHILIYAH Age of Ignorance (Pre – Islamic Age)

MERITS	DEMERITS
Bravery	Idol and Nature worshipping
Eloquency	Usuary
Trustworthy	Slavery
Truthfulness	Tyranny
Superstitious	Robbery
Firm / Convicted	Blood-shed
Courageous	Life-long Enmity
Superb Horsemen	Injustice

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THE ARABIAN PENINSULA

- ARAB SOCIETY, LOCATED IN THE ARABIAN PENINSULA (MODERN-DAY SAUDI ARABIA AND SURROUNDING REGIONS), WAS DEEPLY TRIBAL AND LACKED ANY CENTRAL GOVERNMENT OR UNIFIED MORAL SYSTEM.
- TRIBAL RIVALRIES AND WARFARE WERE FREQUENT, LEADING TO WIDESPREAD SOCIAL INJUSTICE.
- THE KA‘ABA IN MAKKAH HAD BECOME A HUB FOR IDOL WORSHIP, HOUSING HUNDREDS OF IDOLS.
- ETHICAL VALUES WERE WEAK, AND OPPRESSION OF THE POOR AND POWERLESS WAS COMMON.
- WOMEN HAD VERY FEW RIGHTS, AND IN EXTREME CASES, BABY GIRLS WERE BURIED ALIVE DUE TO SOCIETAL SHAME AND IGNORANCE.

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THE PERSIAN EMPIRE

- THE PERSIANS, WHO LIVED IN THE REGION OF MODERN-DAY IRAN AND PARTS OF CENTRAL ASIA, FOLLOWED ZOROASTRIANISM, A RELIGION THAT ORIGINALLY EMPHASIZED BELIEF IN ONE GOD.
- HOWEVER, OVER TIME, IT BECAME DUALISTIC—RECOGNIZING TWO OPPOSING FORCES: GOOD (AHURA MAZDA) AND EVIL (AHRIMAN).
- PERSIAN SOCIETY WAS MARKED BY SHARP CLASS DIVISIONS.
- THE RULING ELITE ENJOYED LUXURY AND POWER, WHILE THE COMMON PEOPLE WERE OFTEN EXPLOITED AND DENIED BASIC RIGHTS OR FREEDOMS.

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THE ROMAN (BYZANTINE) EMPIRE

- THE BYZANTINE EMPIRE, CENTERED IN CONSTANTINOPLE (MODERN-DAY ISTANBUL), SPANNED PARTS OF EASTERN EUROPE, THE BALKANS, ASIA MINOR, THE LEVANT, EGYPT, AND NORTH AFRICA.
- ALTHOUGH CHRISTIANITY WAS THE OFFICIAL RELIGION, MANY ORIGINAL TEACHINGS OF PROPHET ISA (AS) HAD BEEN CHANGED OVER TIME.
- INNOVATIONS SUCH AS THE DOCTRINE OF THE TRINITY WERE INTRODUCED, DEVIATING FROM THE ORIGINAL MONOTHEISTIC MESSAGE. THESE LED TO INTERNAL RELIGIOUS CONFLICTS AND DIVISIONS.
- THE CHURCH HELD GREAT POLITICAL POWER, BUT THIS OFTEN RESULTED IN CORRUPTION AND MORAL DECLINE.
- SOCIAL INEQUALITIES WERE COMMON, WITH WEALTH AND POWER CONCENTRATED IN THE HANDS OF RULERS AND CLERGY, WHILE THE GENERAL POPULATION FACED HARDSHIP.

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JEWISH COMMUNITIES

- BEFORE THE ADVENT OF ISLAM, JEWISH COMMUNITIES WERE FOUND IN SEVERAL REGIONS OF THE WORLD.
- IN THE ARABIAN PENINSULA, PARTICULARLY IN YATHRIB (LATER MADINAH), KHAYBAR, TAYMA, AND FADAK, JEWISH TRIBES SUCH AS BANU QAYNUQA, BANU NADIR, AND BANU QURAYZA PLAYED A SIGNIFICANT ROLE IN THE SOCIAL AND ECONOMIC LIFE OF THE REGION.
- BEYOND ARABIA, JEWISH POPULATIONS ALSO LIVED IN PALESTINE, BABYLON (IRAQ), ALEXANDRIA (EGYPT), AND PARTS OF THE ROMAN EMPIRE, INCLUDING CITIES LIKE ROME AND ANTIOCH.
- WHILE THEY POSSESSED DIVINE SCRIPTURE, SOME TRIBES BECAME RIGID AND PROUD, DEVELOPING A SENSE OF SUPERIORITY OVER OTHERS.
- THEY OFTEN INTERPRETED THEIR TEXTS SELECTIVELY OR ALTERED TEACHINGS, WHICH LED TO INTERNAL DIVISIONS AND A DECLINE IN MORAL AND SPIRITUAL VALUES.

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INDIA (SOUTH ASIA)

- BEFORE THE ADVENT OF ISLAM, INDIAN SOCIETY WAS SHAPED BY A RIGID CASTE SYSTEM, WHICH DIVIDED PEOPLE INTO FOUR MAIN CLASSES:

1. BRAHMINS (PRIESTS)
2. KSHATRIYAS (WARRIORS)
3. VAISHYAS (MERCHANTS)
4. SHUDRAS (LABORERS)

- ONLY BRAHMINS HAD ACCESS TO RELIGIOUS KNOWLEDGE, WHILE LOWER CASTES FACED SOCIAL DISCRIMINATION AND WERE DENIED BASIC RIGHTS.
- HINDUISM, PRACTICED WIDELY, HAD EVOLVED INTO A COMPLEX TRADITION OF IDOL WORSHIP AND RITUALS. BRAHMAN, WAS EXPRESSED THROUGH VARIOUS DEITIES LIKE VISHNU, SHIVA, AND DEVI. SOCIAL INJUSTICES SUCH AS SATI (WIDOW BURNING), CHILD MARRIAGE, ESPECIALLY REFLECTING THE MARGINALIZED STATUS OF WOMEN.

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CHINA AND EAST ASIA

- BEFORE ISLAM, CHINA, LOCATED IN EAST ASIA, AND ITS NEIGHBORING REGIONS SUCH AS KOREA, JAPAN, AND VIETNAM, WERE HEAVILY INFLUENCED BY THE TEACHINGS OF CONFUCIANISM, TAOISM, AND BUDDHISM.
- THESE BELIEF SYSTEMS SHAPED THE CULTURE, PHILOSOPHY, AND RELIGIOUS PRACTICES OF EAST ASIA LONG BEFORE THE RISE OF ISLAM.
- RELIGIONS LIKE BUDDHISM, CONFUCIANISM, AND TAOISM WERE DOMINANT IN THESE REGIONS. THEY PROVIDED VALUABLE PHILOSOPHICAL INSIGHTS AND MORAL TEACHINGS BUT LACKED THE CONCEPT OF A SINGLE CREATOR, WHICH SET THEM APART FROM MONOTHEISTIC RELIGIONS.
- INSTEAD OF OFFERING A CLEAR PATH TO SALVATION OR ADDRESSING SOCIAL JUSTICE, THESE SYSTEMS FOCUSED ON INDIVIDUAL ETHICS, PERSONAL ENLIGHTENMENT, AND SOCIAL HARMONY. RITUALS, MEDITATION, AND MAINTAINING BALANCE WERE CENTRAL PRACTICES.
- HOWEVER, THEY DID NOT PROVIDE A UNIFIED, COMPREHENSIVE MORAL CODE THAT REGULATED DAILY CONDUCT AND SOCIETAL STRUCTURES IN THE WAY THAT OTHER RELIGIOUS TRADITIONS, SUCH AS ISLAM, WOULD LATER OFFER.

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AFRICA AND CENTRAL ASIA

- BEFORE ISLAM, IN AFRICA AND CENTRAL ASIA, MANY SOCIETIES FOLLOWED TRIBAL RELIGIONS, WORSHIPING SPIRITS, ANCESTORS, AND NATURE-BASED DEITIES.
- SUPERSTITION AND MAGICAL PRACTICES WERE COMMON, INFLUENCING DAILY LIFE AND RITUALS. WITHOUT A UNIFIED MORAL OR RELIGIOUS SYSTEM, SOCIAL BEHAVIOR WAS UNREGULATED, LEADING TO TRIBAL CONFLICTS AND SOCIAL INJUSTICES, SUCH AS THE EXPLOITATION OF WEAKER GROUPS.
- IN AFRICA, TRIBAL RELIGIONS WERE PRACTICED ACROSS REGIONS LIKE THE SAHARA AND THE NILE VALLEY, WITH BELIEFS CENTERED AROUND NATURE WORSHIP AND ANCESTRAL SPIRITS.
- IN CENTRAL ASIA, AREAS LIKE KAZAKHSTAN, UZBEKISTAN, TURKMENISTAN, AND PARTS OF AFGHANISTAN WERE HOME TO NOMADIC TRIBES WITH SHAMANISTIC AND ANIMISTIC BELIEFS, BASED ON SPIRITS AND NATURE WORSHIP.

(**SHAMANISM** IS THE BELIEF IN SPIRITUAL LEADERS (SHAMANS) WHO COMMUNICATE WITH SPIRITS OR DEITIES TO HEAL AND GUIDE THE COMMUNITY. **ANIMISM** IS THE BELIEF THAT ALL ELEMENTS OF NATURE, SUCH AS ANIMALS, PLANTS, AND ROCKS, POSSESS A SPIRITUAL ESSENCE AND INFLUENCE HUMAN LIFE.)

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EUROPE POST-ROMAN EMPIRE

- THE DARK AGES, BEFORE THE RISE OF ISLAM, EUROPE FACED SIGNIFICANT CHALLENGES.
- AFTER THE FALL OF THE ROMAN EMPIRE, EUROPE ENTERED THE DARK AGES, WITH REGIONS ACROSS WESTERN AND EASTERN EUROPE, INCLUDING PARTS OF MODERN-DAY ITALY, FRANCE, SPAIN, AND GERMANY, FRAGMENTED INTO WARRING KINGDOMS.
- THIS PERIOD SAW CULTURAL STAGNATION AND SOCIAL UNREST.
- THE CHURCH, WHICH WIELDED IMMENSE POWER, DEVIATED FROM THE ORIGINAL TEACHINGS OF CHRISTIANITY, RESULTING IN EXPLOITATION AND IGNORANCE AMONG THE MASSES.

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GLOBAL SITUATION BEFORE ISLAM

- BEFORE THE ADVENT OF ISLAM, THE WORLD WAS INHABITED BY VARIOUS CIVILIZATIONS AND TRIBES WITH THEIR OWN CUSTOMS, BELIEFS, AND SOCIAL SYSTEMS.
- GREAT EMPIRES LIKE THE GREEKS AND ROMANS HAD ESTABLISHED URBAN CENTERS, WHILE MANY NOMADIC TRIBES ROAMED DESERTS AND STEPPES.
- POLYTHEISM WAS WIDESPREAD, AND RELIGIOUS TEACHINGS WERE OFTEN ALTERED OR FORGOTTEN.
- TRADE ROUTES LIKE THE SILK ROAD CONNECTED DISTANT REGIONS, FACILITATING EXCHANGE OF GOODS AND IDEAS.
- HOWEVER, FREQUENT WARS FOR POWER AND LAND, MORAL CORRUPTION, AND SOCIAL INJUSTICE WERE COMMON. DESPITE CULTURAL DIVERSITY, A SPIRITUAL AND ETHICAL VACUUM PERSISTED ACROSS THE GLOBE.

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THE ROLE OF ISLAM

IN THIS SETTING, ALLAH SENT PROPHET MUHAMMAD (ﷺ) AS THE FINAL MESSENGER TO PROCLAIM TAWHEED (THE ONENESS OF GOD), UPHOLD MORAL INTEGRITY, AND ESTABLISH JUSTICE FOR ALL.

ISLAM EMERGED AS A BEACON OF LIGHT IN AN ERA OVERSHADOWED BY DARKNESS—RESTORING DIGNITY TO WOMEN, DEFENDING THE RIGHTS OF THE WEAK, AND OFFERING CLEAR GUIDANCE FOR HUMANITY'S PHYSICAL AND SPIRITUAL WELL-BEING.

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THANK YOU

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